DRIVEWAY PROJECT CHECKLIST

FOR HOMEOWNERS

Everything you need to plan, permit, and finish your driveway

Use this 8-section checklist before you sign any contract. Tear out the pages you need, take them to site visits, and check items off as you go. Designed for asphalt, concrete, gravel, paver, and resin-bound driveway projects.

8	60+	10
PROJECT PHASES	CHECK ITEMS	PAGES TO TEAR & USE

How to use this checklist

This is a working document. Print it, fold it, take it to site visits, scribble on it. Each phase has a target timeframe and a short list of items to tick off before moving to the next one. If you skip phases, you raise the odds of permit problems, cost overruns, or a finish that fails in the first two winters.

REAL HOMEOWNER SEARCH DEMAND (DATAFORSEO · US · 2026)

Verified monthly U.S. Google search volume for the questions this checklist answers: driveway sealer 33,100/mo · heated driveway cost 6,600/mo · asphalt vs concrete driveway 4,400/mo · chip seal driveway 4,400/mo · concrete driveway cost per sq ft 1,300/mo · driveway cost calculator 720/mo · driveway permit requirements 480/mo · best driveway material 480/mo. Every phase below maps to questions real homeowners type into Google right now.

Eight phases — in order

Phase 1 — Scope & goals

When: 6–12 weeks before you want to break ground. Decide what 'done' looks like before talking to any contractor. Otherwise quotes will not be comparable.

Define the job

- ☐ Decide: new install, full replacement, resurfacing, or repair-in-place.
- ☐ Measure existing or planned driveway: length × width × thickness (in inches).
- ☐ Note slope from garage / house to street — anything over 12% needs special design.
- ☐ List vehicles that will park on it (weight matters — RVs and trucks need thicker base).
- ☐ Decide if you want extras: turnaround, parking pad, lighting, EV charger conduit, heated melt-system.
- ☐ Take 8–10 photos from different angles — you will need these for contractor quotes.

Set non-negotiables

- ☐ Maximum budget (with 15% contingency on top).
- ☐ Earliest start date and 'must be finished by' date.
- ☐ Drainage outcome: where does water need to go?
- ☐ Curb appeal goal: match house, contrast house, or commercial look?

COMMON HOMEOWNER QUESTION (480 SEARCHES/MO · DATAFORSEO)

'Do I need a permit to repave my driveway?' — Usually yes if you change the footprint, slope, or curb cut. Resurfacing the same area in the same material is the most common exemption, but it is town-by-town. 'Driveway permit requirements' gets 480 U.S. searches/mo (DataForSEO, 2026). Phase 5 walks you through finding out.

Phase 2 — Site assessment

When: 5–10 weeks out. Before you pick a material, you have to know what is under it. Skipping this is the #1 cause of failed driveways within 3 years.

Investigate the ground

- ☐ Identify soil type: clay, silt, sand, loam, or rocky. Clay = thicker base required.
- ☐ Run a percolation test (or have one run) — fill a 12" hole with water, time how long it drains.
- ☐ Mark any soft spots, standing water, or visible settling on a sketch.
- ☐ Locate the frost line for your climate zone (deeper = thicker base needed).
- ☐ Call 811 (USA) before you dig — get all utilities marked. This is free and legally required.

Drainage & runoff

- ☐ Identify where water currently flows from the driveway area.
- ☐ Identify where it will flow after the project (must not pool against the house or onto neighbors).
- ☐ Decide if you need channel drains, a swale, or a French drain.
- ☐ Check city stormwater rules — many require capture/infiltration on new impervious surfaces.

Existing conditions

- ☐ Photograph the apron (where driveway meets street) — damage here often shifts permit category.
- ☐ Measure slope at three points: garage threshold, mid-driveway, curb cut.
- ☐ Note overhanging trees and root locations within 10 ft of the driveway path.
- ☐ Identify the curb cut: is it the right width for your widest vehicle?

Phase 3 — Material selection

When: 4–8 weeks out. Pick the material before you collect quotes so every bid covers the same scope.

MATERIAL	TYP. $/SQ FT (2026)	LIFESPAN	MAINTENANCE
Asphalt	$7 – $13	15–20 yrs	Sealcoat every 3 yrs
Concrete	$8 – $18	25–30 yrs	Seal every 5 yrs, control joints
Gravel	$1 – $3	5–10 yrs (w/ topup)	Regrade + topup yearly
Pavers	$15 – $30	30+ yrs	Re-sand joints, pull weeds
Chip seal	$3 – $7	8–12 yrs	Re-chip every 7 yrs
Resin-bound	$20 – $45	15–20 yrs	Power-wash, occasional patch

Decisions to lock down

- ☐ Pick primary material based on lifespan goal, climate, and curb appeal target.
- ☐ For asphalt: confirm hot-mix vs. cold-patch (cold-patch only for repairs, never new installs).
- ☐ For concrete: pick PSI strength (minimum 4,000 PSI for residential) and rebar / wire mesh.
- ☐ For gravel: pick top course (crusher run #57, pea gravel, or recycled asphalt millings).
- ☐ For pavers: pick pattern (herringbone strongest under car weight) and edge restraint type.
- ☐ Confirm finish color in person on a sunny day — colors look different on screens.

REAL HOMEOWNER QUESTION (480 SEARCHES/MO · DATAFORSEO)

'Best driveway material' gets 480 U.S. Google searches every month — medium competition, $2.08 average CPC. There is no universal answer: it depends on climate (freeze-thaw cycles eat asphalt), slope (gravel migrates on >8% grades), and how long you'll own the home. 'Asphalt vs concrete driveway' alone gets 4,400 searches/mo — low competition, $4.54 CPC. The table above gets you 80% of the way to a decision.

Phase 4 — Budget & quotes

When: 4–6 weeks out. Get at least 3 itemized quotes. Verbal numbers do not count.

Itemized quote must include

- ☐ Demolition + haul-away (cubic yards of debris listed separately)
- ☐ Excavation depth and base type/thickness (e.g., 6" of crusher run compacted)
- ☐ Base material price per ton AND number of tons being delivered
- ☐ Surface material price per ton/sq ft AND total quantity
- ☐ Edge restraints, drainage components, and apron work — each as a line item
- ☐ Equipment fees (compactor rental, paver, concrete pump if needed)
- ☐ Labor hours / crew size, dump fees, fuel surcharge if applicable
- ☐ Permit fees (or who is responsible for pulling permits)
- ☐ Cleanup and final inspection walk-through
- ☐ Workmanship warranty in years AND what voids it

Budget framework

A working 2026 budget: materials 40% · labor 35% · equipment & disposal 12% · permits & inspection 3% · contingency 10%. If a quote allocates <5% to base prep, ask why — that's where corners get cut.

Red flags in quotes

- ☐ No base depth specified ('we'll see when we dig')
- ☐ Lump-sum-only pricing with no line items
- ☐ Asphalt thickness under 2" compacted (residential needs 2.5–3")
- ☐ Concrete pour thickness under 4" (needs 5" for vehicle traffic)
- ☐ Deposit demand >30% of total before work starts
- ☐ Verbal warranty only — get it in writing

Phase 5 — Permits & easements

When: 4–8 weeks out (permits take time). This is the most-asked-about phase in our search data. Skipping it can mean fines, a forced tear-out, or a blocked sale later.

Where to ask

- [ ] Your city or township building department — most have a 'driveway / curb cut' form
- [ ] Your HOA (architectural review committee) — separate approval, often required
- [ ] Your state DOT if your driveway meets a state-owned road (access permit required)
- [ ] Your county stormwater office if you're increasing impervious surface area
- [ ] 811 for utility marking — 2–3 business days before any digging

Documents you'll likely need

- [ ] Site plan or survey (often required for new curb cuts)
- [ ] Drainage plan showing where water goes
- [ ] Contractor's license + liability + workers' comp insurance certificates
- [ ] Material spec sheet (asphalt mix design, concrete PSI, etc.)
- [ ] Setback and width measurements vs. property lines and right-of-way

WHEN YOU PROBABLY DO NEED A PERMIT

New curb cut · widening more than ~2 ft · changing slope · increasing impervious area · any work in the public right-of-way · any work in a flood zone · any work on a state highway. Even 'just resurfacing' can trigger one if it changes drainage.

WHEN YOU PROBABLY DON'T

Pure resurface in identical footprint and material · patching potholes · sealcoating · minor gravel topup. Confirm in writing — a 30-second phone call to your building department is the cheapest insurance there is.

Phase 6 — Contractor vetting

When: 3–5 weeks out. Lowest bid is usually the worst bid. Use these checks for every contractor.

Verify the basics

- ☐ State contractor license — search the license number on your state's licensing site
- ☐ General liability insurance: minimum $1M, with current certificate
- ☐ Workers' compensation insurance (so injuries on your property aren't your problem)
- ☐ Better Business Bureau rating and any unresolved complaints
- ☐ Google Business Profile reviews — read the 3-star reviews, not just the 5-stars
- ☐ Years in business under current name (rebrands often hide bad histories)

References & past work

- ☐ Ask for 3 references from jobs done 2+ years ago (lets you see early failure points)
- ☐ Drive past 1–2 of those jobs — look for cracking, edge crumbling, drainage issues
- ☐ Ask: 'What was the biggest problem on that job and how did you handle it?'
- ☐ Ask: 'Who actually does the work — your crew or a subcontractor?'

Contract must specify

- ☐ Exact scope: materials, thickness, square footage, base specs
- ☐ Start date, working hours, expected completion date
- ☐ Payment schedule (recommended: 10% deposit, 40% at base completion, 40% at finish, 10% after 30 days)
- ☐ Change-order procedure (any extras require written approval before work)
- ☐ Workmanship warranty length and what's covered
- ☐ Cleanup standard and where debris goes

Phase 7 — Build day readiness

When: 1 week before through last day of work. Most homeowner regret happens here — from preventable issues that 10 minutes of prep would have caught.

Week before

- ☐ Confirm start date and weather forecast — asphalt and concrete both need dry, warm-ish days
- ☐ Move all vehicles off the driveway and arrange parking elsewhere for the full duration + cure
- ☐ Notify neighbors — equipment is loud and may block their driveway briefly
- ☐ Mark sprinkler heads, low-voltage lighting, and dog fence wires with flags
- ☐ Confirm dumpster or material-staging location and protect lawn with plywood
- ☐ Pull all permits and post them visibly per local requirements

Day-of walk-through with contractor

- ☐ Confirm dig depth in writing — measure it with a tape after excavation
- ☐ Photograph the base after compaction — your warranty starts here
- ☐ Confirm the base type matches the contract (eyeball can't tell crusher run from screenings)
- ☐ Confirm drainage components went in before the surface layer
- ☐ Watch the first load delivered — refuse it if it doesn't match spec

During the pour / paving

- ☐ For concrete: confirm slump test and PSI on the truck ticket
- ☐ For asphalt: confirm temperature at delivery (should be 275–300°F) and rolled while hot
- ☐ For pavers: confirm bedding sand thickness and joint sand type (polymeric vs. regular)
- ☐ Walk the perimeter — edges and apron get cut corners the most often

Phase 8 — Cure, inspect, maintain

When: Day of completion through year 1. The work isn't done when the crew leaves.

Cure & protect

- [ ] Asphalt: no vehicles for 24–72 hrs; no heavy vehicles for 30 days; no sealcoat for 6–12 months
- [ ] Concrete: no foot traffic 24 hrs; no vehicles 7 days; full cure 28 days; first seal at 30 days
- [ ] Pavers: drivable next day; sand joints settle for 2 weeks then re-sand
- [ ] Gravel: drive slowly the first 2 weeks to lock material
- [ ] Keep grass clippings and oak leaves off new asphalt — tannins stain

Final inspection checklist

- [ ] Walk the entire surface — note any cracks, divots, or color variation in writing
- [ ] Spray with a hose: water must flow away from the house, not pool
- [ ] Check the apron and curb cut transition — no lips, no gaps
- [ ] Confirm cleanup: no debris, no fuel/oil stains, lawn restored
- [ ] Get final lien waiver from contractor before final payment
- [ ] File warranty paperwork and add a calendar reminder for the first warranty check (year 1)

Year-1 maintenance plan

- [ ] Month 1: inspect for hairline cracks (normal in concrete, fix in asphalt)
- [ ] Month 6: check drainage performance after first heavy rain
- [ ] Month 12: sealcoat (asphalt) or first joint cleanup (pavers) or regrade (gravel)
- [ ] Save all receipts — they add to home cost basis when you sell

YOU DID IT

If you used this checklist end-to-end, your driveway will outlast 80% of the ones on your block. More guides, calculators, and material deep-dives at drivewayzusa.co.